

PATREON

/ APPLE IAP · REDESIGN EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

BOTH STRUCTURAL EXITS

The governing diagnosis, both paths, and the board decision surface.

PATH A — THE DECOUPLER

“Apple becomes the funding rail. Patreon remains the relationship authority. The Credit Event Log is the truth.”

PATH B — THE ALLOCATION SHIFT

“Apple sees one platform subscription. Patreon governs the allocation of support. The Patronage Allocation Ledger is the truth.”

ARTIFACT FAMILY

#	ARTIFACT	ACCESS
01	Translation Artifact	Public
02	Diagnostic Artifact	Public
03	Redesign Executive Summary	← This document
04	Redesign Artifact — Path A	Restricted
05	Redesign Artifact — Path B	Restricted

SCOPE	CLASSIFICATION
Public board-level decision document for both structural redesign exits. Covers Path A and Path B so the board choice can be made from one document. Not sufficient for implementation. No team should build from this document alone. The restricted Redesign Artifacts contain the full transition sequences, refusal gates, schemas, admissibility conditions, and handoffs.	Public executive summary. Derived from locked Diagnostic Artifact and restricted Redesign Artifacts A and B. Not commissioned by Patreon or Apple. In a live engagement, restricted artifacts are released only after acceptance. In this public exemplar, they exist as demonstration artifacts.

JUDGMENT BOUNDARY

JUDGMENT BOUNDARY: *No claim about bad faith, internal intent, undisclosed systems, or adjudicated liability. Structural diagnosis derived from public evidence only. Does not say the 30% fee is the root structural failure. Does not say Apple acted illegally. Does not propose legal circumvention.*

SECTION 0

WHAT THIS DOCUMENT IS

Path A preserves Patreon's identity behind a translation layer. Path B changes Patreon's identity by replacing creator-level payment with platform-level allocation. That is the fork. Both exits are valid. Only one can be chosen.

THIS IS	THIS IS NOT
The public board decision surface covering both structural exits	A roadmap, compliance migration plan, or product optimisation programme
A summary of corrected primitive, truth object, minimum replacement, proof conditions, and board verdict for each path	Sufficient for implementation — the restricted artifacts define the full builder-grade specification
Derived from locked Diagnostic Artifact and restricted Redesign Artifacts A and B	A combined or hybrid path — Path A and Path B are mutually exclusive structural futures

FINALITY CONDITION

Path A and Path B are mutually exclusive. Attempting both recreates the current structural collapse: multiple payment geometries, no coherent primitive governing any of them.

SECTION 1

GOVERNING DIAGNOSIS AND DECISION SURFACE

Patreon was founded on the premise that the billing event and the creative act can be economically linked. Apple's IAP system is built on a different premise: standardised subscription events governed by Apple's grammar. These are different economic objects. At the moment a fan taps "Join" inside the iOS app, the Primitive Switch occurs: the relationship-coded act of support becomes a transaction-coded purchase on Apple's terms. Every visible failure — the 30% fee, multiplier confusion, refund paradox, remittance delay, web checkout workarounds, repeated policy reversals — follows from that switch. The correction is not better billing communication. The correction is to stop letting Apple's payment rail define Patreon's patronage relationship.

The two exits differ in how they address the Primitive Switch:

DECISION DIMENSION	PATH A — THE DECOUPLER	PATH B — THE ALLOCATION SHIFT
Strategic meaning	Preserve Patreon	Transform Patreon
Approach	Intercept and translate. Preserve bilateral patronage behind an Apple-compatible rail.	Remove the surface where the switch occurs. Creator-level economics no longer appear at the iOS boundary.
What Apple sees	Apple-compatible subscription funding a credit ledger	One platform subscription to Patreon — no creator-level economics
Truth object	Credit Event Log	Patronage Allocation Ledger
Fiscal character	Capital: Reconciliation Reserve (platform-fee funded) covers Apple-Patreon timing mismatch	Operational: Payor-of-record compliance, tax reporting, jurisdictional approval required
Legal change	Lower — entitlement accounting, App Store compliance	Significant — Patreon becomes payor of record; creator tax docs change
Main risk	Translation drift	Category collapse
Strategic character	Continuity-preserving correction	Category-transforming replacement

RECOMMENDED DECISION

If the strategic aim is to preserve Patreon's existing creator-fan category, Path A is the primary continuity-preserving exit. Path B should only be selected if Patreon intentionally chooses category transformation and accepts the legal, accounting, and identity consequences.

SECTION 2

PATH A — THE DECOUPLER

Redesign Spine:

PATH A — THESIS

Apple becomes the funding rail. Patreon remains the relationship authority. The Credit Event Log is the truth.

ELEMENT	SPECIFICATION
Corrected primitive	Two-layer architecture: creator-defined patronage preserved inside Patreon (Patronage Layer) while only Apple-compatible subscription events are exposed at the iOS boundary.
Truth object	Credit Event Log: primary operational record. Governs entitlement and payout. Apple never writes to it. Cannot be overwritten by Apple subscription data.
Apple's role	Apple's role is confined to the external payment rail. Patreon governs entitlement, credit state, publication-triggered payout, and reconciliation internally.
Minimum replacement	Credit Event Log + Apple subscription mapping + publication-triggered debit + reconciliation reserve + fan and creator visibility. Five must coexist at executive-summary level. The restricted specification defines the full eight-component minimum.
Proof condition	Same pressure → different response. Apple policy changes no longer cause creator chaos, fan confusion, or manual migration load.
Primary recapture risk	Credit Event Log becomes secondary or symbolic; Apple subscription state governs entitlement again.
No-circumvention boundary	Path A does not hide payment from Apple. It preserves Patreon's native patronage object behind an Apple-compatible payment rail. Requires App Store compliance review before launch.

KERNEL TEST

KERNEL TEST: If the Credit Event Log does not exist, is not primary, cannot be inspected, or can be overwritten by Apple subscription data — the redesign has failed regardless of how clean the Apple-facing interface appears.

Board decision required:

BOARD QUESTION	REQUIRED ANSWER
What economic object does iOS purchase?	A funding event for Patreon's internal credit system, not the creator-fan relationship itself.
What must Apple never define?	Entitlement, creator payout, publication-triggered economics, or the meaning of the support relationship.

What must stop before engineering begins?	Multiplier-as-translation, auto-migration under current logic, web checkout as structural fix, creator trust as instruction layer, simultaneous pursuit of both paths.
What proves success?	Apple policy changes no longer create creator-facing chaos, manual support load, or loss of output-linked economics.
What invalidates success?	Credit Event Log becomes symbolic, Apple subscription state governs entitlement, creators keep explaining workarounds.

What stops immediately:

- Treating the multiplier as economic translation
- Auto-migrating per-creation creators under current logic
- Treating web checkout as the structural fix
- Treating Apple reversals as communication problems
- Pursuing both Path A and Path B simultaneously

DEPENDENCY SUMMARY — PATH A

DEPENDENCY SUMMARY — PATH A: *Reconciliation authority declared → Vanish List executed → Credit Event Log specified → Refusal gates implemented → Patronage layer built → Translation engine built → Reconciliation engine → Fan interface → Creator interface → Legacy migration → Drift monitoring. Full sequence in restricted Redesign Artifact A.*

PROOF CONDITION — PATH A

HARDEST-CASE PROOF: *A per-creation creator stops publishing for one month. The fan remains subscribed through Apple. No Credit Event Log debit fires. Fan credits roll over. Creator receives no output-linked income. Apple funded the relationship. Patreon governed it. The Credit Event Log was the truth.*

FAKE PROGRESS TEST

FAKE PROGRESS — PATH A: *(1) Apple subscription still defines the creator-fan relationship; (2) Credit Event Log exists but does not govern entitlement or payout; (3) creators still explain pricing and web workarounds; (4) success measured by migration completion; (5) multiplier remains as fallback.*

BOARD VERDICT — PATH A

BOARD VERDICT — PATH A: Adopt the two-layer membership architecture. Apple may process subscription payment. Apple must not define the creator-fan relationship. Patreon preserves creator-defined patronage through the Credit Event Log, maps Apple payment into credit allocation, debits credits on publication events, resolves entitlement from credit balance, and absorbs refund/remittance mismatch through the reconciliation reserve. Path A is the continuity-preserving, lower-risk, identity-consistent exit.

SECTION 3

PATH B — THE ALLOCATION SHIFT

Path B is not a fix that preserves Patreon as-is. It is a new category of platform. Fans fund Patreon once; Apple sees one platform subscription; fans allocate support to creators inside Patreon; Patreon becomes the payor of record to creators.

Redesign Spine:

PATH B — THESIS

Apple sees one platform subscription. Patreon governs the allocation of support. The Patronage Allocation Ledger is the truth.

ELEMENT	SPECIFICATION
Corrected primitive	Platform-level patronage allocation: fans hold one funding relationship with Patreon and distribute support across creators using Allocation Rule Objects inside Patreon's system.
Truth kernel (Path B)	A creator who publishes work receives income from Patreon, according to allocation rules explicitly set by fans who chose to support that creator, on terms visible to both parties at commitment.
Truth object	Patronage Allocation Ledger: primary record of fan balances, allocation rules, allocation events, creator payouts, and reconciliation. Apple never writes to it.
Apple's role	Apple's role is confined to the platform subscription layer. Creator-level economics remain inside Patreon's allocation layer and are not represented as Apple-visible purchase events. Requires legal and App Store compliance review before launch.
Minimum replacement	Patronage Allocation Ledger + Platform Subscription Layer + Fan Allocation Interface + Publication-Triggered Allocation Engine + Patreon as Payor of Record. Five must coexist at executive-summary level. The restricted specification defines the full ten-component minimum.
Proof condition	Same pressure → zero Apple impact. Apple grammar changes produce no creator-level engineering change, no creator communication burden, and no architecture rebuild.

Primary recapture risk	Category collapse — allocation becomes financial budgeting, not relational support.
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ADOPTION PRINCIPLE

ADOPTION PRINCIPLE: *Creators and fans do not adopt allocation because it is structurally elegant. They adopt it only if the interface preserves directness: named creators, clear allocation rules, visible publication triggers, proof that support reaches the intended creator. If the interface makes support feel like managing a balance rather than supporting a person, the ledger may work technically while the category fails.*

IDENTITY INVARIANT — PATH B

IDENTITY INVARIANT — PATH B: *The allocation interface must never display credits, tokens, or a generic budget balance as the primary frame. It must always present “Active support for [Creator Name]” as the primary display. If financial framing dominates relational framing, category collapse has begun.*

ADMISSIBILITY BOUNDARY

ADMISSIBILITY BOUNDARY: *Product readiness is not launch readiness. Path B is admissible only when the legal, tax, accounting, payout, dispute, and creator documentation structures required by payor-of-record status exist. A working allocation interface with an incomplete payor-of-record architecture is not launchable.*

Board decision required:

BOARD QUESTION	REQUIRED ANSWER
Is Patreon willing to become a different category of platform?	Yes, if Path B is selected. This cannot be treated as a billing migration.
Who is the payor of record?	Patreon. Creators are paid by Patreon based on internal allocation rules. Fan names do not appear on creator tax documents.
What must Apple never see?	Creator names, per-creation logic, allocation rules, creator payouts, or any creator-level economic detail.
What must stop?	Bilateral subscription as core identity, multiplier logic, designing allocation as a feature, assuming per-creator payout means bilateral payment, deferring payor-of-record legal architecture.

What proves success?	Apple grammar changes produce zero creator-level engineering change, zero creator communication, zero architecture rebuild.
What invalidates success?	Category collapse: fans feel they are managing a budget; creators feel paid by a platform pool.

What stops immediately:

- Treating bilateral creator-fan subscription as non-negotiable identity
- Designing allocation as a feature rather than as the new governing primitive
- Treating the fan's "I pay this creator" mental model as immovable
- Deferring payor-of-record legal architecture — begin at Move 0, not Move 8
- Pursuing both Path A and Path B simultaneously

DEPENDENCY SUMMARY — PATH B

DEPENDENCY SUMMARY — PATH B: *Platform identity declaration → Payor-of-record legal review (begin immediately — longest-lead item) → Vanish List executed → Patronage Allocation Ledger specified → Refusal gates implemented → Platform Subscription Layer → Allocation Engine → Reconciliation Layer → Fan Allocation Interface → Creator Payout System confirmed → Legacy migration → Drift monitoring. Full sequence in restricted Redesign Artifact B.*

PROOF CONDITION — PATH B

HARDEST-CASE PROOF: *A fan subscribes to Patreon through iOS and allocates £8 to Creator A when Creator A publishes. Creator A publishes. The Allocation Engine executes the fan's rule, debits the Patronage Account, writes the Patronage Allocation Ledger entry, and queues payout. No creator-level event is represented to Apple. The fan then redirects allocation from Creator A to Creator B. Apple receives no creator-level event, no subscription modification, no creator data. That is the proof that creator-level economics have moved out of Apple's reach.*

FAKE PROGRESS TEST

FAKE PROGRESS — PATH B: *(1) Allocation interface exists but fans still think in terms of "subscribing to creators"; (2) Patronage Allocation Ledger exists but does not govern allocation or payout; (3) legal/tax documentation still presents fans as payor; (4) allocation interface feels like a wallet or fund manager; (5) Apple policy change still requires a Patreon engineering response.*

CENTRAL RISK PRINCIPLE

PATH B FAILS IF IT SOLVES APPLE WHILE DESTROYING PATRONAGE. *Primary recapture vectors: (1) category collapse — interface presents balance to manage, not named creator relationships; (2) bilateral reversion — per-creator subscription objects reintroduced; (3) payor-of-record erosion — documentation drifts toward fans as payor; (4) ledger displacement — Apple subscription record queried for creator income instead of Patronage Allocation Ledger.*

BOARD VERDICT — PATH B

BOARD VERDICT — PATH B: *Adopt Path B only if the board is willing to change what Patreon is. This is not a billing migration. It is a category transformation. Patreon becomes the payor of record. The Patronage Allocation Ledger becomes the truth object. Creator-defined economics are preserved inside the allocation layer, invisible to Apple. This document does not recommend Path B over Path A. It specifies what Path B requires so the decision cannot be mistaken for a feature upgrade.*

SECTION 4

THE STRUCTURAL CHOICE

DIMENSION	PATH A — THE DECOUPLER	PATH B — THE ALLOCATION SHIFT
What Patreon becomes	Same platform, structurally upgraded	Different platform, new economic model
Apple's authority	Managed through translation layer	Removed from the Apple-visible creator-economics layer
Bilateral relationship	Preserved inside Patreon's system	Retired as payment; preserved as allocation
Truth object	Credit Event Log	Patronage Allocation Ledger
Fiscal character	Capital: Reconciliation Reserve (platform-fee funded, covers Apple-Patreon timing mismatch)	Operational: Payor-of-record compliance, tax reporting, jurisdictional approval in all markets
Legal change	Lower — entitlement accounting, App Store compliance	Significant — Patreon becomes payor of record; creator tax docs change in all jurisdictions
Main risk	Translation drift — Credit Event Log becomes symbolic	Category collapse — relational frame fails even if ledger works correctly
Choose if...	Patreon wants to remain recognisably Patreon and will maintain a permanent translation layer	Patreon intentionally chooses category transformation and accepts identity, legal, and accounting consequences

GOVERNING LAW OF THIS SUMMARY

If leadership cannot choose between preserving and transforming, no redesign should begin. Ambiguity at the identity layer becomes incoherence at the architecture layer.

SECTION 4.1

CONSEQUENCE OF DEFERRAL

CONSEQUENCE OF DEFERRAL

Each month without a structural exit:

- *More per-creation creators are auto-migrated under the broken multiplier — active structural harm written into the record before the truth object exists.*
- *Engineering capacity is consumed by compensatory fixes that cannot exit the failure class — compliance iterations, repricing tools, web checkout workarounds, migration tooling.*
- *Creator trust erodes. Each policy reversal and forced migration spends trust creators built with their own communities.*
- *The off-platform ghost structure grows. Discord posts, Twitter threads, and community workarounds become more load-bearing, not less.*
- *The November 1, 2026 deadline forces auto-migration under the current broken logic if no redesign is built. There is no neutral holding position. Delay is not neutral. It compounds.*

SECTION 5

NEXT STEPS FOR THE BOARD

Steps common to both paths:

#	ACTION	OWNER
1	Accept the governing diagnosis. The problem is a primitive conflict, not a compliance migration.	CEO and executive leadership
2	Execute the Vanish List. Pause multiplier-based migration, stop treating web checkout as structural fix.	CPO and engineering lead
3	In a live engagement: sign the Diagnostic Acceptance Protocol (Diagnostic Artifact, Appendix A) within 14 days. Restricted delivery begins only after acceptance.	CEO, CPO, CTO, CFO
4	Choose Path A or Path B. This is an identity decision, not a product or engineering decision. Do not pursue both.	Board and CEO

IF PATH A IS SELECTED	IF PATH B IS SELECTED
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5A. Authorise Move 0: Reconciliation Authority Declaration. Confirm loss pooling via reserve. Release restricted Redesign Artifact A.	5B. Confirm category transformation decision. Accept payor-of-record identity and legal consequences.
	6B. Begin payor-of-record legal, tax, and accounting work immediately — the longest-lead item unique to Path B.
	7B. Authorise Move 0: Platform Identity Declaration and Reconciliation Authority. Release restricted Redesign Artifact B.

POST-LAUNCH INTEGRITY AUDIT

POST-LAUNCH INTEGRITY AUDIT: The board should authorise a 6-month structural integrity audit after the first migration cohort. The audit confirms the truth object (Credit Event Log or Patronage Allocation Ledger) is governing entitlement and payout — not the Apple subscription record. Any subsequent product decision that bypasses the truth object for convenience must be treated as a structural breach, not a UX improvement.

CLOSING STATEMENT

The diagnosis is not that Patreon lacks effort, communication, or billing tooling. The diagnosis is that Patreon's founding patronage model cannot be faithfully expressed inside Apple's payment grammar. Path A preserves Patreon by separating Apple's payment rail from the creator-fan relationship. Path B transforms Patreon by moving creator-level economics out of Apple's reach entirely. Both are valid structural exits. Only one can be chosen. The choice is not between two features. It is between two futures.

WHAT THIS DEMONSTRATES

This executive summary demonstrates what a structural replacement specification produces at board level: a governed diagnosis, two clearly specified structural exits, minimum replacement conditions, proof standards, and a decision surface the board can act on. The Translation Artifact explains the failure in plain language for wider audiences. The restricted Redesign Artifacts A and B contain the complete builder-grade specification for whichever path is selected.

Prepared independently by Jamie Forrester, Independent Systems Architect, Edinburgh, UK. Not commissioned by Patreon or Apple. Derived from public evidence only.

For the restricted Redesign Artifacts or related structural diagnosis work: hello@jamieforrester.com · jamieforrester.com